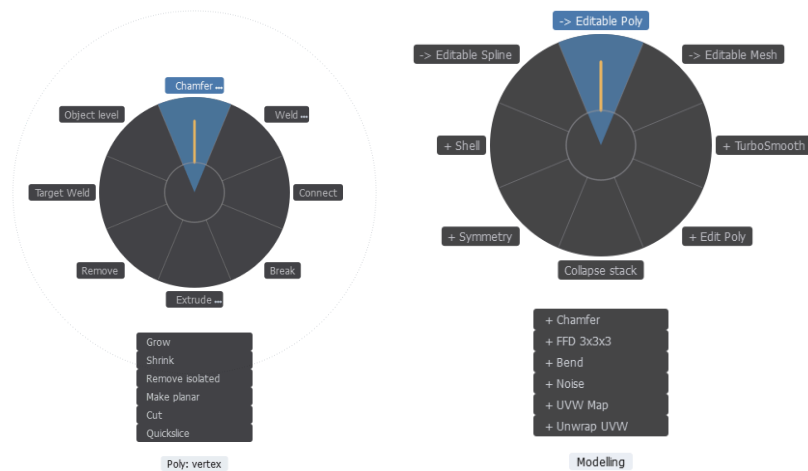


MarkingForge

QuickStart - the easy version

3DS MAX 2027 · VERSION 1.5.4 · ABOUT 20 MINUTES



Twelve short lessons in plain words. The first six teach you to use the dials. The other six show how to change them. Want every detail? The **full QuickStart** and the **Reference** have it all - you will find them in **MarkingForge > Documentation**.

Contents

1. What MarkingForge does
2. Using the dials
 1. Your first dial
 2. One key, the right tools
 3. The fast way - a flick
 4. Three dots and the dotted circle
 5. Dials that save you time
 6. Which key is which
3. Changing the dials
 7. Put your own command on a dial
 8. Shorter names and extra rows
 9. A different key
 10. Ready-made scripts
 11. More dials on one key
 12. Colours
4. Good to know
5. If something goes wrong
6. Support, bug reports and feature requests

What MarkingForge does

You hold a key, a round menu appears under your mouse, you move towards a command and let go. That is all.

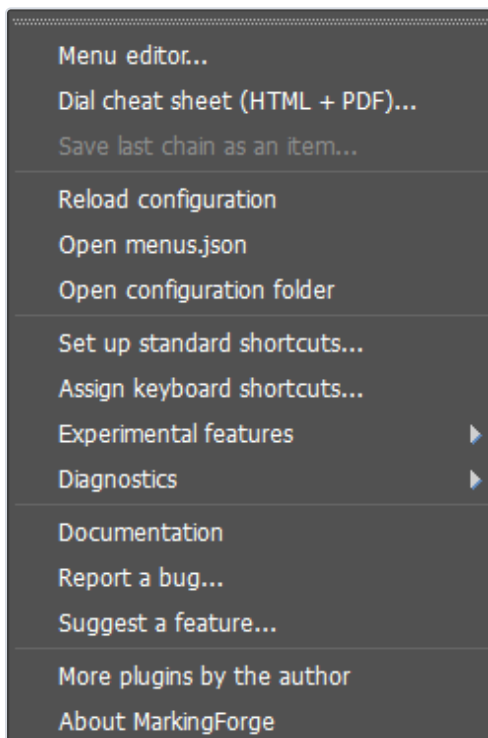
The round menu is called a **dial**. Each dial has eight commands around it, one in each direction. There are 24 dials, on **Alt**, **Ctrl+Alt** and **Shift+Alt** with the numbers 1 to 8.

You do not read the dial - you remember the direction. After a few days your hand knows it, and you stop looking.

Nothing can go wrong. Let go in the middle of the dial (or press Esc) and nothing happens. Ctrl+Z undoes anything a dial did.

Before you start

- 1 Look for **MarkingForge** in the 3ds Max menu bar. Not there? See the Installation Guide.
- 2 The dials get their keys by themselves the first time. To check, open **MarkingForge > Set up standard shortcuts...**



The MarkingForge menu.

PART 1

Using the dials

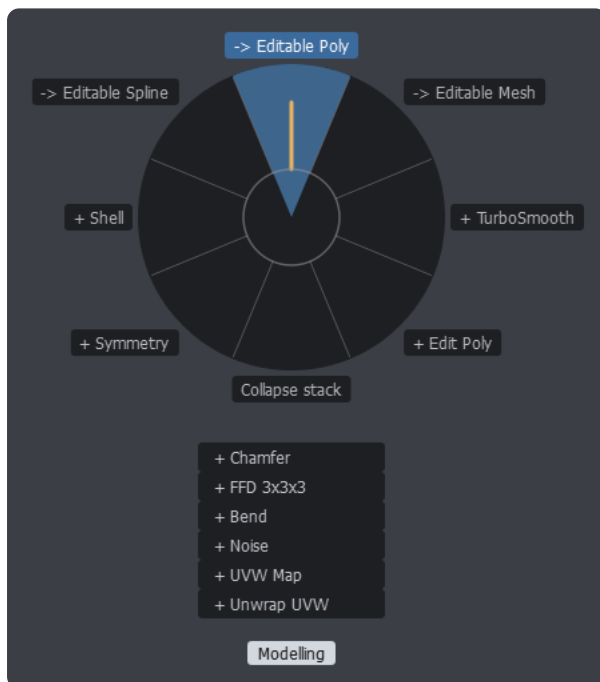
Six lessons. Open an empty scene and try each one as you read.

1

Your first dial

2 min

- 1 Put the mouse over a viewport.
- 2 Hold **Alt+3**. A dial appears: **Create**.
- 3 Move up, to **Box**, and let go. Now drag a box in the viewport as usual.
- 4 Select the box. Hold **Alt+1**, move up to **-> Editable Poly** and let go.



Alt+1, mouse moved up: the box becomes an Editable Poly.

RESULT

Your box is now an Editable Poly. You did it without a menu or the command panel.

A caption with > at the end opens more commands. Hold Alt+3, move down through **Shapes >** without letting go - the dial now shows shapes. Move up to **Line** and let go.

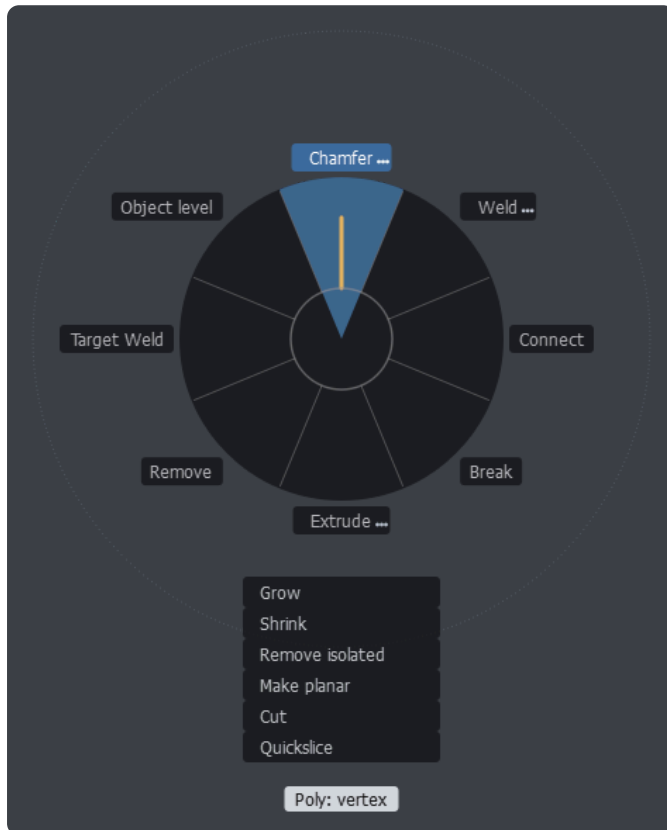
2

One key, the right tools

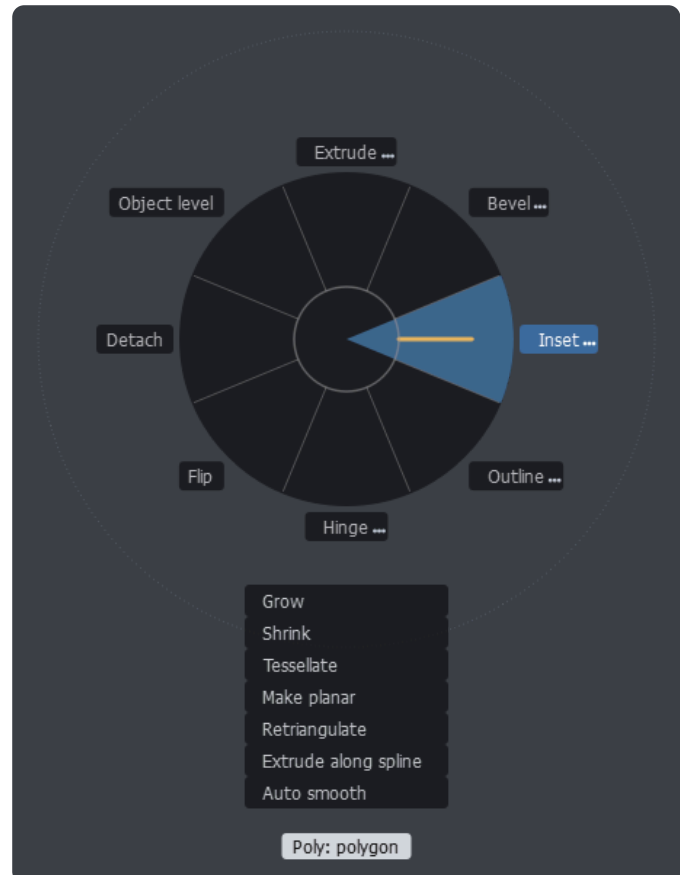
3 min

The dial changes with what you are doing. Alt+1 on vertices shows vertex tools, on polygons it shows polygon tools.

- 1 Keep the Editable Poly selected and press **1** (vertices).
- 2 Hold **Alt+1**: Chamfer, Weld, Connect... Move up to **Chamfer** and let go.
- 3 Press **4** (polygons), click a polygon and hold **Alt+1**: now you see Extrude, Bevel, Inset...
- 4 Move up-left (**Object level**) to go back to the whole object.



Vertices.



Polygons.

3

The fast way - a flick

3 min

You do not have to wait for the dial. Press the key and move the mouse at the same moment, then let go. The command runs and the dial never shows. This is called a **flick**.

TRY IT

Do each one five times - slowly first, then without looking:

Press, then move	What happens
Alt+4, up	Zoom to see everything
Alt+4, down	Isolate what is selected (again = back)
Alt+5, up / down	Select all / select none
Ctrl+Alt+1, up / right	Move tool / scale tool
Alt+7, up	Undo

RESULT

A day later you will do these without thinking. That is the whole idea.

4

Three dots and the dotted circle

3 min

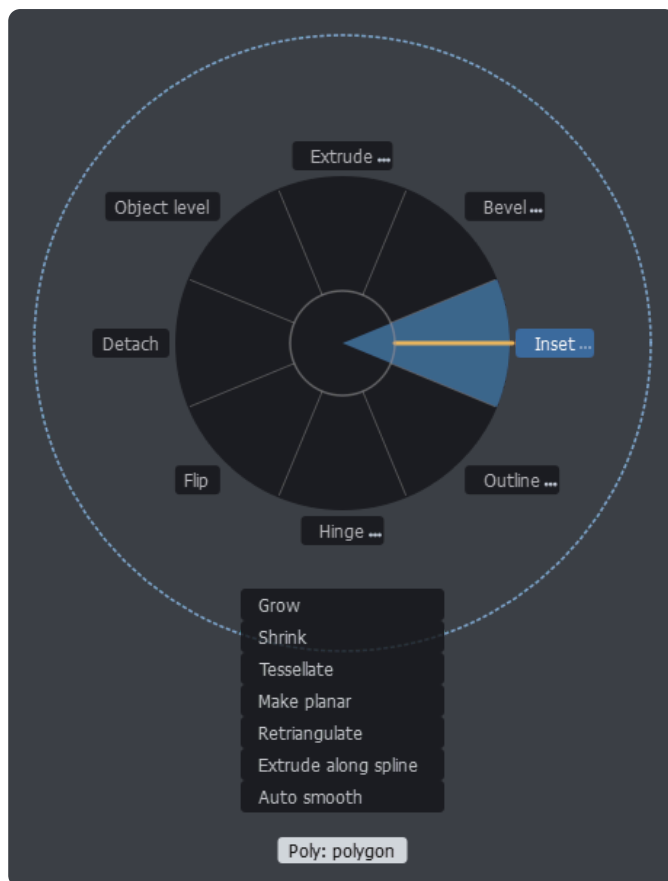
Some captions end with **three dots** - Extrude, Bevel, Inset... These commands have a settings window.

- Let go **near the dial**: the settings window opens.
- Move **further out**, past the **dotted circle**, and let go: no window. The command starts the same way as its button in the Modify panel - for Inset, Extrude or Bevel you then drag in the viewport.

The dotted circle lights up when you are past it. A flick works the same: a short one opens the window, a long one does not.



Near the dial: the window will open.



Past the dotted circle: no window.

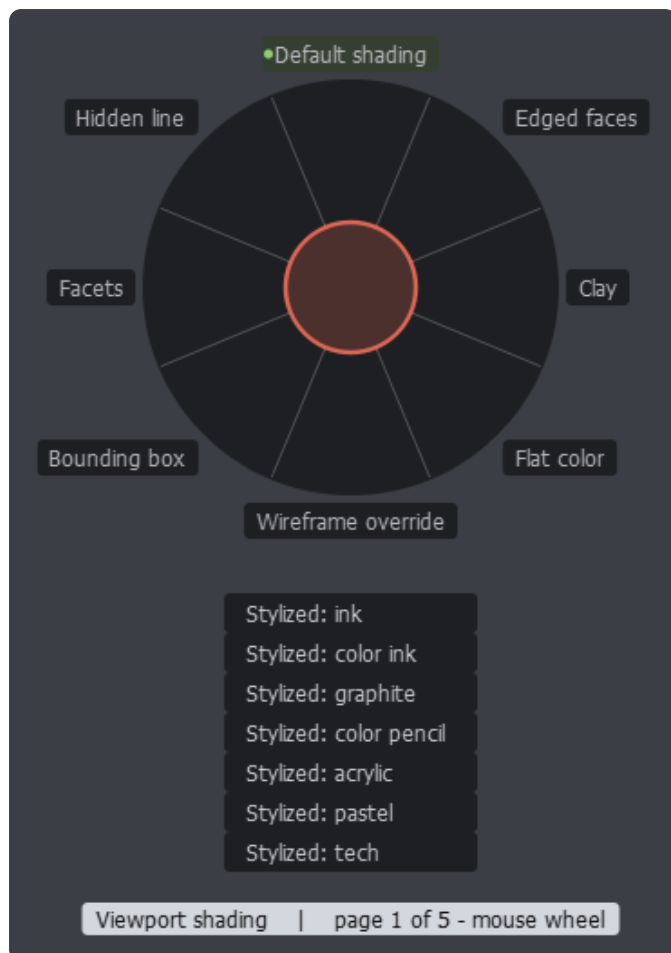
Rows under the dial. Some dials also have a short list under them. Keep holding the key, move down to a row and click it.

5

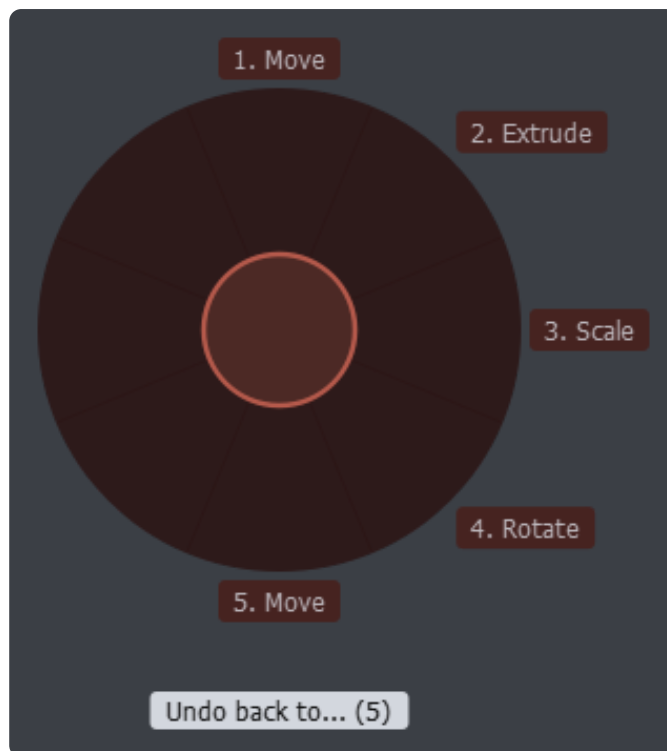
Dials that save you time

4 min

Key	What it shows
Alt+7	Your last steps, by name. Up undoes one step, the next one round undoes two, and so on.
Alt+8	The commands you used last. A flick up repeats the last one.
Alt+6	The modifiers of the selected object. Pick one to open it.
Alt+2	How the viewport looks: shading, wireframe, clay... Keep holding and turn the mouse wheel towards you for more pages: lights and shadows, what is shown, the views.
Alt+2 , wheel one step away from you	The hotbox : every 3ds Max menu as tiles. Point at a title, then at a command.



Alt+2 - the viewport.



Alt+7 - undo by name.

6

Which key is which

2 min

The number is the place, the modifier key is the row. Count from a key you know.

Key	Dial	Key	Dial	Key	Dial
Alt+1	Modelling	Ctrl+Alt+1	Transform	Shift+Alt+1	Materials
Alt+2	Viewport shading	Ctrl+Alt+2	Modifiers	Shift+Alt+2	Animation
Alt+3	Create	Ctrl+Alt+3	Show and hide	Shift+Alt+3	Scene
Alt+4	View	Ctrl+Alt+4	Viewports	Shift+Alt+4	File
Alt+5	Selection	Ctrl+Alt+5	Viewport display	Shift+Alt+5	Selection sets
Alt+6	Modifier stack	Ctrl+Alt+6	Snaps and grid	Shift+Alt+6	UV mapping
Alt+7	Undo	Ctrl+Alt+7	Align and pivot	Shift+Alt+7	Tools and setup
Alt+8	Recent commands	Ctrl+Alt+8	Render	Shift+Alt+8	Lights and cameras

Print the cheat sheet and keep it next to the keyboard for the first week: **MarkingForge > Dial cheat sheet (HTML + PDF)...**

PART 2

Changing the dials

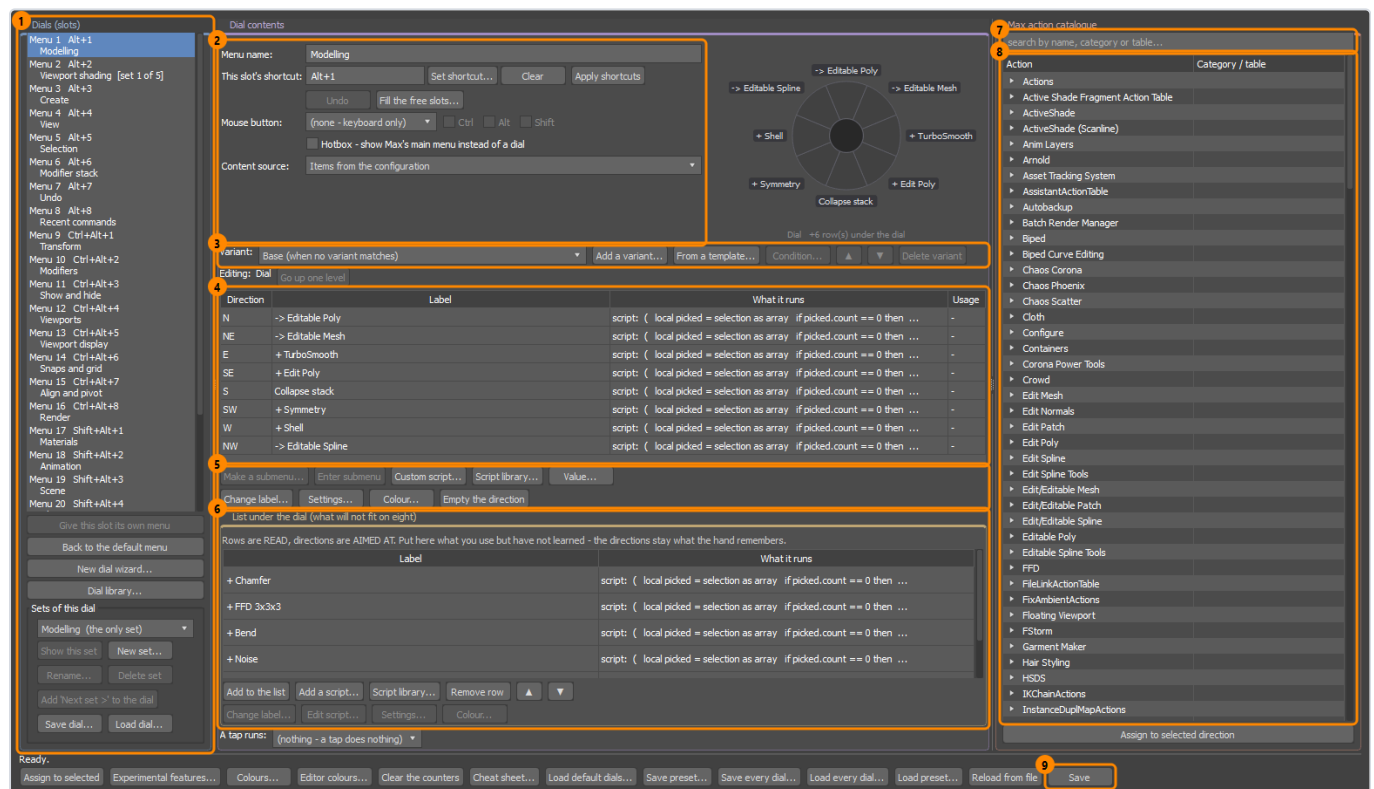
Six lessons in the menu editor. Nothing changes on your dials until you press **Save**, so try anything you like.

7

Put your own command on a dial

4 min

Open **MarkingForge > Menu editor...** On the left are your dials, in the middle the eight directions of the chosen dial, on the right every 3ds Max command.



The menu editor.

Example: on the **File** dial (Shift+Alt+4), swap *Save copy as* for **Export Selected**.

- 1 On the left, click **Menu 20** (the File dial).
- 2 In the search box, type **Export Selected**.
- 3 Click **Export Selected...** in the list below it.
- 4 Click the **SE** row (bottom-right direction).
- 5 Press **Assign to selected direction** - or just drag the command onto the row.

6 Press **Save**.

Direction	Label	What it runs	Usage
N	Save	action: Main UI	-
NE	Save as...	action: Main UI	-
E	Save incremental	action: Main UI	-
SE	Export Selected...	action: Main UI (name from Max)	-
S	Open...	action: Main UI	-
SW	Import...	action: Main UI	-
W	Merge...	action: Main UI	-
NW	Hold	action: Main UI	-

Done: the bottom-right direction now runs Export Selected.

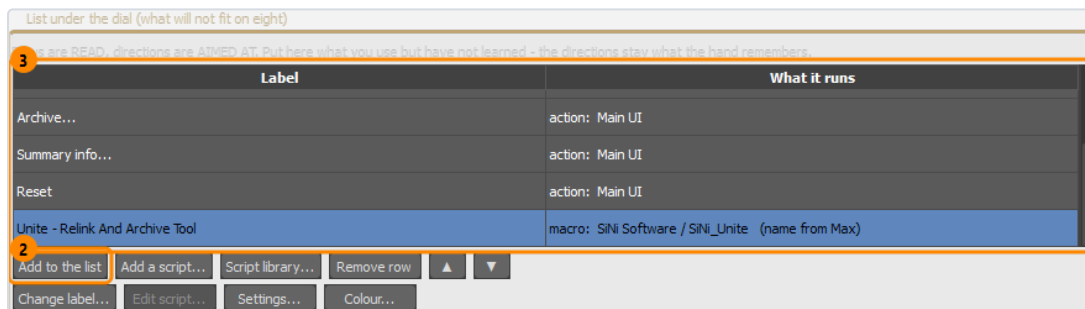
TRY IT

Hold Shift+Alt+4 in a viewport: bottom-right is Export Selected.

8 Shorter names and extra rows

2 min

- 1 A name too long? Click its direction, press **Change label...**, type a shorter one.
- 2 More than eight commands? Find a command and press **Add to the list**. It shows as a row under the dial. Up to twelve rows.
- 3 Press **Save**.

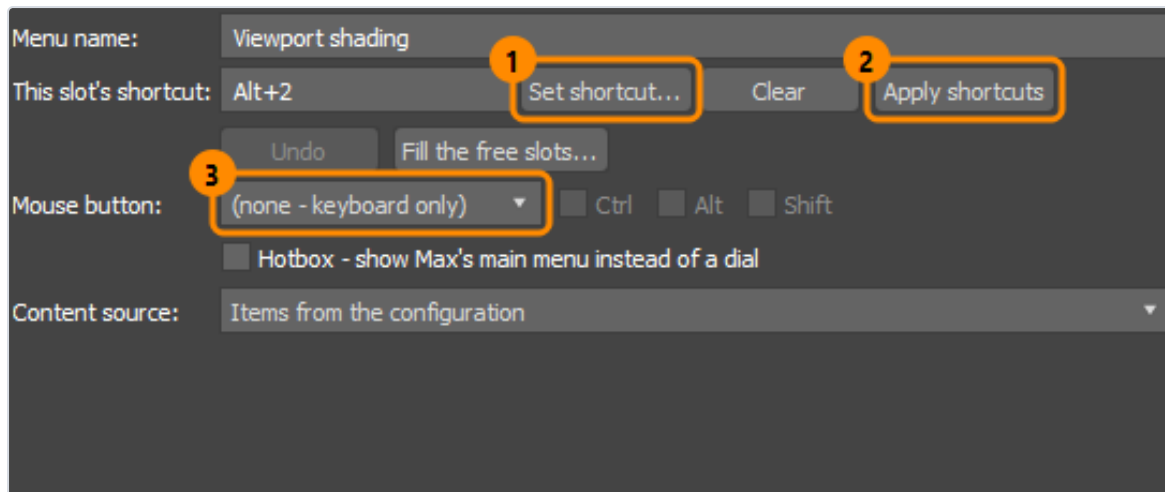


The rows under the dial, and Add to the list.

9 A different key

2 min

- 1 Click the dial on the left.
- 2 Press **Set shortcut...**, press the keys you want, click **Set**.
- 3 Press **Apply shortcuts**. Your other 3ds Max shortcuts stay as they are, and a backup is made.
- 4 Press **Save**.



Set shortcut (1) and Apply (2).

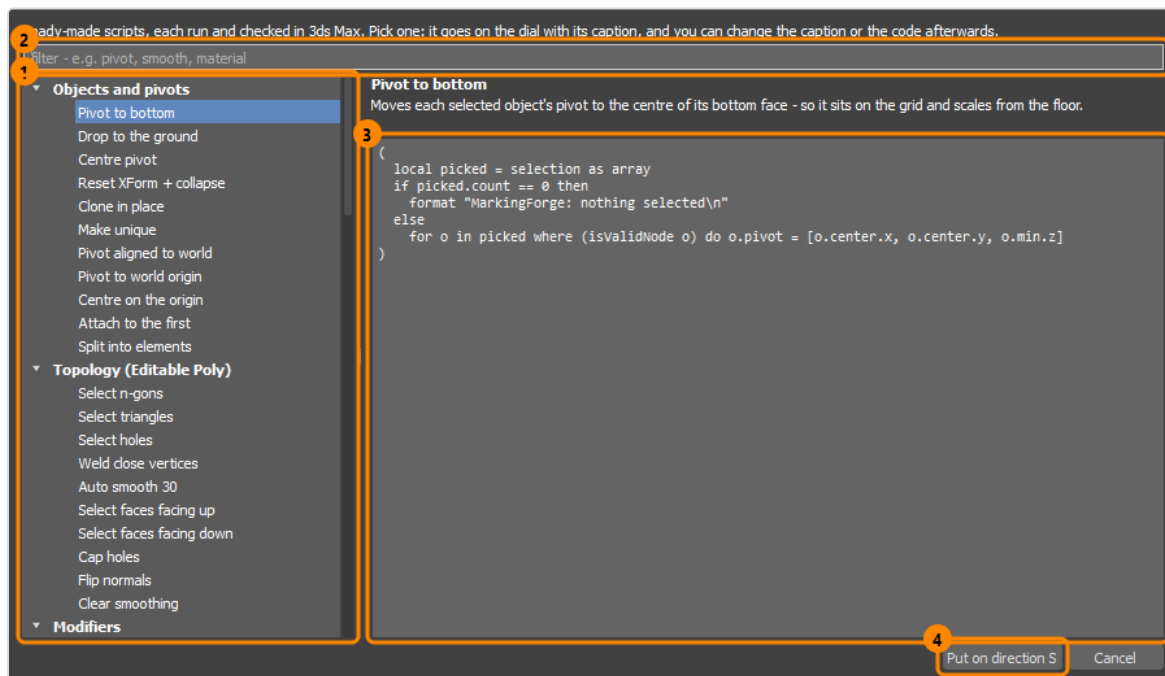
10

Ready-made scripts

3 min

MarkingForge comes with 102 small ready-made tools - pivot to the bottom, select n-gons, drop to the ground and many more. You do not write anything.

- 1 Click a direction (or use the list under the dial).
- 2 Press **Script library...**
- 3 Click a script: the right side says what it does. Type in the filter to find one - *pivot, smooth...*
- 4 Press **Put on direction ...** or **Add to the list**, then **Save**.



The script library.

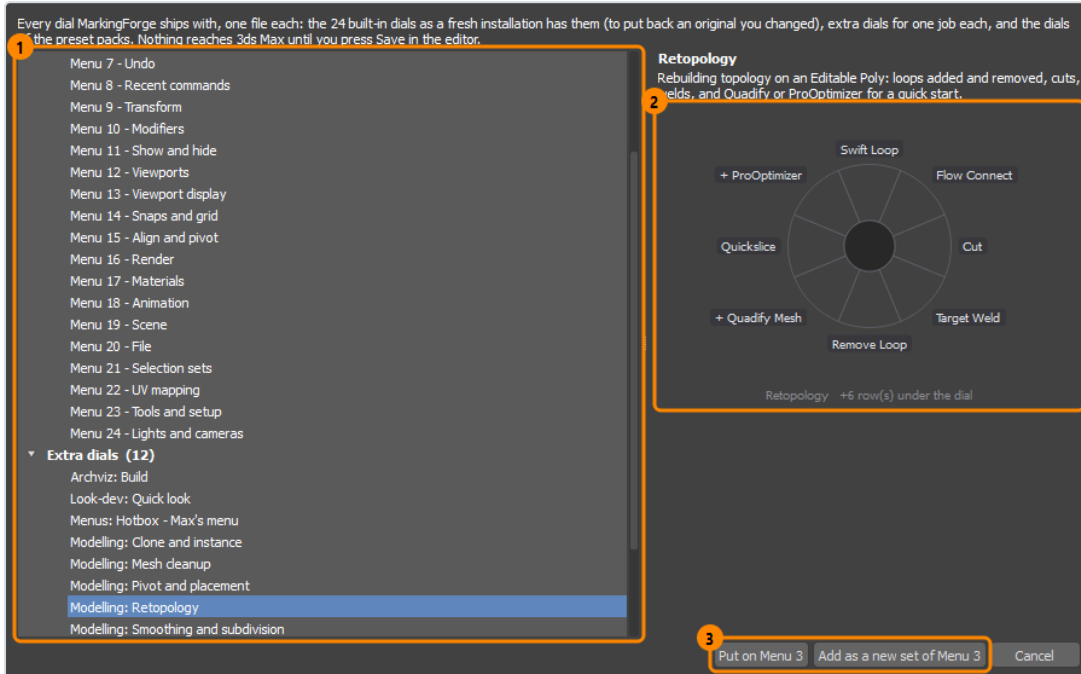
11

More dials on one key

3 min

One key can hold several dials, like pages. Hold the key and turn the mouse wheel to flip between them. Alt+2 already works this way.

- 1 Click the dial on the left - say **Menu 1**.
- 2 Under the list of dials press **Dial library...**
- 3 Pick a ready-made dial - Retopology, Mesh cleanup, Smoothing and subdivision... there are 51.
- 4 Press **Add as a new set of Menu 1**, then **Save**.
- 5 In 3ds Max hold **Alt+1** and turn the wheel towards you: the new page.



The dial library.

The key remembers the page you used last - even after you restart 3ds Max. **Restore Menu N** in the same window brings a dial back as it was.

12

Colours

2 min

- 1 Press **Colours...** at the bottom of the editor.
- 2 Choose **Every dial** or just this one.
- 3 Pick one of the thirty ready-made looks and press **Use this**.
- 4 OK, then **Save**.



The thirty ready-made looks.

A different colour for each dial helps you see at once which one opened.

Good to know

- **The dial looks at what is under the mouse.** Point at a spline and Alt+1 shows spline tools, even if a box is selected.
- **A tap** (press and let go without moving) can run the command you usually use next. It shows with a dashed outline on the dial.
- **Number sliders.** A direction can set a number by how far you move - the viewport's field of view, for example. Lesson 15 of the full QuickStart shows five of them.
- **More switches** - several commands in one gesture, search by typing - are in **MarkingForge > Experimental features**.
- **Your own scripts, different dials for different situations, dials that fill themselves** - all in the full QuickStart.

Three rules for your own dials

Opposites face each other

Select all / select none, hide / unhide - on opposite sides.

Do not move what you know

Once your hand knows a place, leave it. Add, do not shuffle.

Short names

One or two words. Your hand needs the direction, not the text.

If something goes wrong

What happens	What to do
Holding the key does nothing	MarkingForge > Set up standard shortcuts...
I changed something, but the dial is the same	Press Save in the editor.
A different dial opened than I expected	The dial follows what is under the mouse. Move over empty space and try again.
A caption is red	That command is not in this 3ds Max (a missing plugin). Put another one there.
Where is the hotbox?	Hold Alt+2 and turn the mouse wheel one step away from you.
I want the original dials back	In the editor: Load default dials...

More problems and their fixes are in the full QuickStart and the Reference.

Still stuck? Open an issue at github.com/looki666/MarkingForge/issues or write to forgeplugins@gmail.com. **MarkingForge > Report a bug...** puts your 3ds Max and MarkingForge details on the clipboard, ready to paste.

Support, bug reports and feature requests

ISSUES	github.com/looki666/MarkingForge/issues
E-MAIL	forgeplugins@gmail.com
WEB	https://forgeplugins.tech (forgeplugins.tech - more plugins by the author)

Bug reports and feature requests are best opened as issues on GitHub - the forms there ask for exactly what is needed, and you can follow the fix. Questions, and anything you would rather not post publicly (licence, purchase), go to the e-mail address. Every message is read.

Reporting a bug

- 1 In 3ds Max choose **MarkingForge > Report a bug...** - it copies your 3ds Max version, MarkingForge version, configuration summary and start-up log to the clipboard. It works even when the plugin did not load.
- 2 Open github.com/looki666/MarkingForge/issues and pick **Bug report** - or answer **Yes** in the dialog to write an e-mail to forgeplugins@gmail.com instead.
- 3 Say what you did, what you expected and what happened instead, then paste the details with **Ctrl+V**.
- 4 Add a screenshot if you can. When the problem is in one dial, attach a preset of it (editor > **Save preset...**).

Suggesting a feature

Open an issue with the **Feature request** form, choose **MarkingForge > Suggest a feature...**, or simply write. Describe what you would like to do and how you do it today - a concrete example from your work says more than a list of wishes. Ideas for new built-in dials, commands and options are all welcome.

Nothing is sent by the plugin itself: the details go to the clipboard and your own e-mail program, so you see everything that leaves your computer. MarkingForge has no network access.